

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 13: Ascension

Day 44 Since Awakening - 06:52

The daily quest notification appeared as Hayami completed their final repetition. Twenty-one consecutive days of going beyond the limit. The new Unwavering Dedication bonus meant this completion would give four stat points instead of three.

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!] [ACHIEVEMENT: BEYOND THE LIMIT] (21 days in a row) **[+4 to all stats]** (Unwavering Dedication bonus active) **[Random Reward Box obtained!] [Premium Reward Box obtained!]**

Hayami checked the elixir status:

[ELEMENTAL AWAKENING ELIXIR] [TIME REMAINING: 8 hours, 23 minutes]

Still active from yesterday's wind training. Eight hours was more than enough time to push both lightning and earth to B-rank. The elixir's 200% proficiency gain, combined with their Ring of Elemental Unity's 10% boost and focused training, would make it possible.

Current standings:

- Lightning Manipulation (C-Rank 38%)
- Earth Manipulation (C-Rank 15%)

Lightning needed 62% to reach B-rank. Earth needed 85%. Both were achievable.

Time to work.

LIGHTNING MANIPULATION TRAINING - HOUR 1-4

Hayami started with lightning since it was closer to B-rank. They pulled out the Basic and Intermediate Lightning Manuals—they'd long since mastered all exercises in both, but reviewing them at their current power level revealed deeper understanding.

"Lightning is not merely electricity—it is transformation, conversion of potential to kinetic, the shortest path between states of being."

At C-rank, Hayami controlled lightning. At B-rank, they would become lightning.

They practiced the most advanced techniques from the Intermediate Manual, pushing their execution to perfection. Lightning coating that covered their entire body for minutes instead of seconds. Chain lightning that branched to twenty targets instead of twelve. Precision strikes that could hit a pinpoint target from fifty meters away.

[LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: C-Rank (38% → 54%)]

But mastery required more than technical skill. It required innovation. Creating new applications, discovering possibilities the manuals didn't cover.

Hayami combined lightning with their new wind affinity. Ionized air conducted electricity better than normal air. By manipulating wind pressure and composition, they could create channels that guided lightning with perfect precision.

[IMPROVED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: LIGHTNING CHANNELS] [Use wind to create conductive pathways for lightning attacks. Increases range and accuracy by 50%.]

[LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: C-Rank (54% → 69%)]

Then they experimented with lightning's interaction with earth. Grounding. Electricity naturally sought earth, wanted to discharge into it. But what if Hayami controlled both the lightning and the earth it discharged into?

They created a circuit—lightning flowing from their hand, through a stone they were manipulating, back to their other hand. The stone acted as a conductor and amplifier, increasing the lightning's power while giving it structure.

[IMPROVED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: GROUNDING CIRCUIT] [Channel lightning through earth constructs to amplify power and create complex attack patterns.]

[LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: C-Rank (69% → 84%)]

The final insight came from understanding lightning's dual nature. It was both energy and plasma—electricity and superheated air. By controlling both aspects simultaneously through lightning and wind manipulation, Hayami could create plasma constructs that didn't follow normal electrical pathways.

They formed a sphere of contained plasma between their hands—not just electricity, but matter in its fourth state. The sphere was stable, controllable, and devastatingly powerful.

[ADVANCED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: PLASMA MANIPULATION] [Combine lightning and wind to create and control plasma. Opens new possibilities for both offensive and defensive applications.]

[LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: C-Rank (84% → 100%)]

[CONGRATULATIONS!] [LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: C-RANK → B-RANK (0%)]

The breakthrough was explosive. Lightning surged through Hayami's body, not burning but integrating. Every nerve became a conductor. Every cell learned to channel electricity. Their body itself became a living circuit.

[LIGHTNING MANIPULATION: B-RANK ACHIEVED]

[All lightning-based skills upgraded to B-rank effectiveness]

[New Passive Acquired: LIVING LIGHTNING] [Your body has fully integrated with lightning element. You can convert your body to electrical energy for brief moments, allowing you to move through conductive materials, dodge attacks by becoming intangible, and strike with your entire being as a weapon. Physical attacks deal additional lightning damage equal to 30% of base damage.]

[Existing Skills Enhanced:]

- Advanced Lightning Strike → Master Lightning Strike (damage increased 300%, can pierce multiple targets, virtually no cooldown)
- Lightning Domain → Thunder Domain (radius increased to 20 meters, damage increased, can selectively exclude allies)
- Lightning Step → Thunder Flash (distance increased to 15 meters, can change direction mid-dash, leaves afterimages)

[New Skills Unlocked:]

- **Plasma Burst:** Release a wave of plasma energy in all directions. Damage scales with Intelligence. Range: 25 meters. Costs 300 Mana. Cooldown: 2 minutes.
- **Electromagnetic Pulse:** Disable all electronic devices and magical constructs in a 30-meter radius. Disrupts enemy barriers and shields. Costs 250 Mana. Cooldown: 5 minutes.
- **Railgun:** Channel lightning through a metal projectile, launching it at hypersonic speeds. Extreme damage, extreme range. Costs 400 Mana. Cooldown: 3 minutes.

Hayami flexed their fingers, watching electricity dance across their skin effortlessly. B-rank lightning manipulation meant they could call down actual lightning from the sky if conditions were right. Could disable entire buildings with an EMP. Could move faster than the eye could track.

One element done. One to go.

[TIME REMAINING ON ELIXIR: 4 hours, 11 minutes]

Earth was further behind—only C-rank 15%. It needed 85% growth to reach B-rank. But Hayami had learned from lightning's progression. Technical mastery was important, but true advancement came from understanding the element's fundamental nature.

Earth wasn't just stone and soil. It was foundation. Permanence. The weight of time compressed into solid matter. It was memory—rocks that remembered being molten, minerals that remembered being stars.

Hayami placed both hands on the roof's concrete surface and extended their consciousness downward. Through the building's structure, through Tokyo's foundations, deep into the bedrock beneath the city. Earth welcomed them like an old friend.

They practiced large-scale manipulation. Raising pillars of stone from the roof surface, not small constructs but massive formations. Creating intricate patterns, testing the limits of their control.

[EARTH MANIPULATION: C-Rank (15% → 31%)]

Then they experimented with earth's interaction with other elements. Earth conducted heat—fire could be channeled through stone, controlled, focused. Earth blocked wind but could be shaped to redirect it. Earth grounded lightning but could also amplify it.

Multi-element synergy. That was the key to the Arbiter path.

Hayami created a stone construct and ran lightning through it while simultaneously using wind to cool specific parts and fire to heat others. The stone fractured along precise lines they'd programmed through temperature differentials and electrical stress.

[IMPROVED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: ELEMENTAL FORGING] [Use multiple elements simultaneously to reshape earth into precise, complex forms. Allows creation of custom constructs and temporary equipment.]

[EARTH MANIPULATION: C-Rank (31% → 48%)]

They pushed harder, combining earth manipulation with their growing understanding of physics and material science. Stone wasn't uniform—it had grain, structure, weak points. By sensing these internal patterns through Seismic Sense and manipulating them with earth control, Hayami could transform ordinary stone into something closer to steel.

They compressed a basketball-sized rock, forcing its molecular structure to reorganize, until it was dense as metal and twice as hard.

[ADVANCED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: DENSITY MANIPULATION] [Alter the internal structure of earth materials. Increase or decrease density, hardness, and durability. Can create ultra-hard constructs or make stone as light as foam.]

[EARTH MANIPULATION: C-Rank (48% → 66%)]

The final push required thinking beyond solid stone. Earth included everything formed from the planet—not just rock, but metal, crystal, even sand and dust. Each was earth expressing itself differently.

Hayami gathered sand from cracks in the roof and shaped it. Not just moving it, but controlling individual grains, making them flow like water while maintaining solid properties. A weapon made of sand that could shift between fluid and rigid states instantly.

[ADVANCED TECHNIQUE DEVELOPED: GRANULAR CONTROL] [Manipulate earth at the granular level—sand, dust, small particles. Can create weapons and constructs that shift between fluid and solid states. Difficult to block or defend against.]

[EARTH MANIPULATION: C-Rank (66% → 83%)]

So close. Hayami could feel the B-rank threshold, just beyond reach. They needed one more insight.

They thought about earth's true nature. It wasn't just physical—it was conceptual. Foundation. Stability. The unmoving center around which everything else turned. Earth was patience, endurance, the slow crushing weight of inevitability.

What if they applied that concept to themselves?

Hayami rooted their consciousness in the earth beneath them, becoming as immovable as stone. Their body gained earth's weight, earth's permanence. They became the foundation, the anchor point that nothing could shift.

[PROFOUND INSIGHT ACHIEVED: IMMUTABLE FOUNDATION] [Understand earth not as matter but as concept. Become the unshakeable center.]

[EARTH MANIPULATION: C-Rank (83% → 100%)]

[CONGRATULATIONS!] [EARTH MANIPULATION: C-RANK → B-RANK (0%)]

The transformation was different from lightning's explosive integration. Earth sank into Hayami's bones, making them denser, heavier, more solid. Their skeleton became unbreakable. Their muscles gained the endurance of stone. They became, quite literally, grounded.

[EARTH MANIPULATION: B-RANK ACHIEVED]

[All earth-based skills upgraded to B-rank effectiveness]

[New Passive Acquired: EARTHBORN] [Your body has fully integrated with earth element. You cannot be moved against your will if you choose to root yourself. Your physical defense is increased by 50%. You

can sense everything that touches the ground within 200 meters. Physical attacks gain earth properties, ignoring 30% of enemy defense.]

[Existing Skills Enhanced:]

- Advanced Stone Spear → Master Stone Lance (size increased, can create barrages of lances, penetrates all but the strongest defenses)
- Advanced Earth Wall → Earth Fortress (can create multi-layered defensive structures, virtually indestructible at B-rank)
- Advanced Earth Golem → Stone Titan (size increased to 5 meters, combat intelligence improved, can command up to 3 titans simultaneously)

[New Skills Unlocked:]

- **Earthquake:** Create a localized earthquake in a 50-meter radius. Destroys structures, knocks down enemies, reshapes terrain. Costs 500 Mana. Cooldown: 5 minutes.
- **Stone Prison - Enhanced:** Trap enemies in a cage of ultra-dense stone. Nearly unbreakable. Duration: until destroyed or dismissed. Costs 300 Mana. Cooldown: 3 minutes.
- **Mountain's Endurance:** Grant yourself or an ally the endurance of stone. Damage reduction increased by 70% for 1 minute. Costs 350 Mana. Cooldown: 5 minutes.

Hayami stood on the roof, feeling the connection to earth deepen beyond anything they'd experienced before. They could sense the entire building's structure, every support beam, every crack, every stress point. Their awareness extended through the ground for two hundred meters in all directions.

Two elements at B-rank. One at C-rank. One at E-rank.

[CURRENT ELEMENT STATUS:]

- Lightning Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Earth Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Wind Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Fire Manipulation (E-Rank 0%) - UNLOCKED

Three elements at B-rank. The Arbiter path was progressing faster than Hayami had dared hope.

They checked the time: 2:47 PM. The elixir had worn off about thirty minutes ago, but the momentum was too good to stop now.

Time to open reward boxes and see what the System offered next.

REWARD BOX OPENING SESSION

Hayami went inside, sat on their bed, and pulled up their inventory.

[RANDOM REWARD BOXES: 7] [PREMIUM REWARD BOXES: 7]

Fourteen boxes total. They decided to open all the random boxes first, then one premium box to see what higher-tier rewards looked like now that they'd advanced so far.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #1]

[CONTENTS:] [CONSUMABLE: Health Potion (Superior) x5] [Effect: Restores 500 HP instantly. Can be used in combat.]

[CONSUMABLE: Mana Potion (Superior) x5] [Effect: Restores 400 Mana instantly. Can be used in combat.]

Good. Their consumable stock had been running low after recent raids.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #2]

[CONTENTS:] [EQUIPMENT: BELT OF ELEMENTAL STORAGE] [+5 to all stats] [Passive: Increases inventory capacity by 100 slots] [Passive: Allows instant access to equipped weapons and consumables without opening inventory]

Utility equipment. Hayami equipped it immediately, feeling the inventory expansion take effect.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #3]

[CONTENTS:] [ITEM: SKILL ENHANCEMENT STONE (LESSER) x3] [Effect: Increases proficiency of one skill by 5%. Single use.]

[ITEM: STAT ENHANCEMENT POTION (TEMPORARY) x2] [Effect: Increases all stats by +10 for 1 hour. Single use.]

Temporary buffs. Useful for difficult raids.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #4]

[CONTENTS:] [EQUIPMENT: GLOVES OF PRECISION] [+6 Agility, +6 Sense] [Passive: Increases accuracy of all attacks by 20%] [Passive: Reduces fumble chance to nearly zero]

Decent, but the Gauntlets of Earthshaper were better for Hayami's playstyle. They put these in storage for potential sale or trade.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #5]

[CONTENTS:] [CONSUMABLE: EXPERIENCE CRYSTAL (MEDIUM) x2] [Contains 25,000 experience points each. Crush to absorb.]

Fifty thousand experience total. Enough for at least three level-ups. Hayami saved these—better to use them strategically before difficult content.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #6]

[CONTENTS:] [ITEM: TRAINING MANUAL - ADVANCED FIRE MANIPULATION]

Perfect timing. They'd just unlocked fire yesterday and now had the advanced manual.

[ITEM: ELEMENTAL AWAKENING ELIXIR]

Another one! These were incredibly valuable. Hayami now had two in storage.

[RANDOM REWARD BOX #7]

[CONTENTS:] [EQUIPMENT: NECKLACE OF MANA FLOW] [+12 Intelligence] [Passive: Mana regeneration increased by 40%] [Passive: Reduces mana cost of all skills by 10%]

Excellent. Hayami equipped it immediately, their mana pool jumping.

[MANA: 2,710/2,710] (with new necklace)

All random boxes opened. Good rewards across the board—consumables, equipment, training materials. The System was consistent in providing useful items.

Now for the premium box.

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX]

[OPENING...]

The golden light spilled out, brighter than usual. As Hayami's power had increased, had the System's rewards scaled up as well?

[CONTENTS:]

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: BRACERS OF THE FOUR WINDS] [Description: Ancient bracers said to harness the power of cardinal directions] [+15 Agility, +10 Intelligence] [Passive: All wind-based attacks deal 40% additional damage] [Passive: Movement speed increased by 30%] [Passive: Can manipulate wind currents within 100-meter radius even without active skill use] [Active Skill: CARDINAL GALE -

Summon wind from all four directions simultaneously, creating a devastating convergence attack.

Damage scales with Wind proficiency and Intelligence. Costs 500 Mana. Cooldown: 10 minutes.]

Incredible. Hayami equipped the bracers—sleek bands that wrapped around their forearms, etched with directional symbols that seemed to shift and rotate. The moment they settled into place, Hayami felt their connection to wind amplify dramatically.

[SKILL BOOK ACQUIRED: ELEMENTAL DOMAIN FUSION] [Description: Legendary technique allowing multiple elemental domains to be layered simultaneously] [Effect: Can activate Lightning Domain, Earth Domain, and Wind Domain at the same time, creating a multi-element field that grants all bonuses simultaneously. Domains can interact and combine for synergistic effects.]

This was game-changing. Hayami absorbed the knowledge immediately. Being able to layer all three domains meant creating a battlefield where they controlled lightning, earth, and wind simultaneously. Enemies would be fighting in a space where every element was weaponized against them.

[CONSUMABLE ACQUIRED: STAT BREAKTHROUGH ELIXIR] [Description: Ultra-rare consumable that temporarily removes stat growth limiters] [Effect: For 24 hours, all stat gains are doubled. All training is twice as effective. All experience gains are doubled. Single use. Cannot be stacked with other boosting effects.]

Hayami read the description three times. This wasn't just an enhancement—this was a multiplier on everything. If used strategically before a major raid or training session, the gains would be astronomical.

They saved it carefully. This was for a special occasion.

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: RING OF ELEMENTAL MASTERY] [+10 to all stats] [Passive: All elemental attacks deal 25% additional damage] [Passive: Switching between elements now costs no mana] [Passive: When using an element at B-rank or higher, gain 20% cooldown reduction on all skills]

Another ring. Hayami now had three rings—Mana Regeneration, Elemental Unity, and Elemental Mastery. All three equipped on different fingers, each one enhancing their multi-element combat style.

They checked their updated stats with all the new equipment:

[LEVEL: 30] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 3)]

[STATS] (with all equipment and bonuses)

- Strength: 161 (base 73 + 54 equipment + 15% class)
- Agility: 227 (base 69 + 91 equipment + 15% class + 25% traits)
- Vitality: 145 (base 65 + 44 equipment + 15% class)

- Intelligence: 244 (base 85 + 88 equipment + 15% class)
- Sense: 163 (base 67 + 53 equipment + 15% class)
- Mana: 2,940/2,940

Intelligence: 244. Solidly S-rank for mage specialists.

Agility: 227. High A-rank, approaching S-rank.

All other stats: A-rank tier.

Hayami stood and moved experimentally. The Bracers of the Four Winds made them feel weightless, like gravity was optional. The Living Lightning passive meant their reflexes operated at electrical speeds. The Earthborn passive made them immovable when rooted.

They were becoming something beyond a normal Hunter. Beyond even what high-ranks typically achieved. The Arbiter path was transforming them into something unique.

But there was still work to do. Three elements at B-rank. One at E-rank. Three elements still locked.

Hayami pulled out the Advanced Fire Manipulation Manual and the two Elemental Awakening Elixirs. Tomorrow, after the daily quest, they'd start on fire.

For now, they had training to do. Lightning and earth at B-rank opened new possibilities—combining them at that tier would create effects more powerful than anything they'd achieved before.

Time to experiment.

EVENING TRAINING SESSION

Hayami returned to the roof and activated their new Elemental Domain Fusion technique.

"Lightning Domain! Earth Domain! Wind Domain!"

Three overlapping spheres of elemental energy exploded into existence, each one ten to twenty meters in radius. The combined effect was staggering—lightning crackling through the air, stone rising and falling in geometric patterns, wind howling in controlled vortexes.

Within this tri-element field, Hayami was god. They controlled everything—the electricity in the air, the earth beneath their feet, the wind that carried both. Enemies caught in this space would be assaulted from all angles simultaneously.

They practiced combinations:

- Wind carrying lightning in controlled paths

- Earth constructs acting as lightning rods and amplifiers
- Lightning superheating earth to create glass and lava
- Wind cooling molten earth to create instant barriers
- All three elements flowing together in synchronized attacks

[COMBAT MASTERY INCREASING] [MULTI-ELEMENT COORDINATION: ADVANCED]

By sunset, Hayami had developed several devastating combinations that would make even S-rank Hunters pause. The Arbiter path wasn't about specialization—it was about synthesis. Making elements work together in ways no single-element user could match.

Their phone buzzed. Message from Himiko.

[HIMIKO: Hey! Want to do a raid tomorrow? I found a C-rank Gate, independent party forming. Could use two more. Interested?]

[HAYAMI: What's the pay?]

[HIMIKO: ¥180k each plus loot share. Party leader seems legit this time—I checked his history, all successful raids, no incidents.]

[HAYAMI: Sure. Send me the details.]

[HIMIKO: Awesome! 10 AM meeting time, Shibuya. I'll text you the exact location tonight.]

[HIMIKO: Also, want to grab breakfast before? There's this place that does amazing tamagoyaki.]

[HAYAMI: Okay.]

[HIMIKO: YAY! See you at 8 AM then! Sleep well!]

Hayami smiled. Friendship was still strange—the casual invitations, the assumption that they'd want to spend time together, the easy back-and-forth. But it was nice. Good, even.

They went inside, showered, ate dinner, and reviewed the day's progress:

- Lightning: C-rank → B-rank
- Earth: C-rank → B-rank
- All random boxes opened
- One premium box opened, excellent rewards
- Intelligence: 244 (S-rank tier)

- Agility: 227 (high A-rank)
- Multiple new skills and equipment

Forty-four days since Awakening. Three elements at B-rank. Level 30. Stats that rivaled A-rank Hunters and exceeded them in some areas.

Tomorrow: breakfast with a friend, then a C-rank raid. Simple. Normal. The kind of life a Hunter could actually live, not just survive.

Hayami set their alarm and went to sleep, the Crown of the Arbiter glowing softly with four active gems.

The grind continued. But it was becoming something more than just grinding.

It was becoming a life.

[END OF CHAPTER 13]

[UPDATED STATUS SUMMARY]

[LEVEL: 30] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 3)] [DAYS SINCE AWAKENING: 44]

[ELEMENTS]

- Lightning Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Earth Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Wind Manipulation (B-Rank 0%) - MASTERED
- Fire Manipulation (E-Rank 0%) - UNLOCKED

[STATS] (with all equipment)

- Strength: 161
- Agility: 227 (high A-rank / approaching S-rank)
- Vitality: 145
- Intelligence: 244 (S-rank for specialists)
- Sense: 163
- Mana: 2,940

[NEW EQUIPMENT]

- Bracers of the Four Winds (+15 AGI, +10 INT, 40% wind damage, Cardinal Gale skill)

- Belt of Elemental Storage (+5 all stats, inventory expansion)
- Necklace of Mana Flow (+12 INT, 40% mana regen, 10% cost reduction)
- Ring of Elemental Mastery (+10 all stats, 25% elemental damage, free element switching)

[NEW SKILLS]

- Elemental Domain Fusion (layer multiple domains simultaneously)
- Multiple B-rank elemental skills for lightning and earth
- New passives: Living Lightning, Earthborn

[INVENTORY]

- Premium Reward Boxes: 6
- Random Reward Boxes: 0
- Experience Crystals: 2 (25k each)
- Elemental Awakening Elixirs: 2
- Stat Breakthrough Elixir: 1 (legendary)
- Various consumables and enhancement stones

[FINANCES]

- Current Balance: ¥1,187,000
- Expected after tomorrow's raid: ¥1,367,000+

[NEXT OBJECTIVES]

- Tomorrow: Breakfast with Himiko, then C-rank raid
- Soon: Train fire to mastery
- Future: Push remaining elements to B-rank, continue Arbiter progression